training, equipment, technology, and exchange of information. The initiation of military-to-military ties was another component of the new Sino–Iranian relationship. In September 2014, two PLAN destroyers made the first-ever visit by PRC warships to an Iranian port, Bandar Abbas.[14] This was a significant move. Previously, PLAN warships had carefully avoided Iranian ports. PLAN warships first entered the Indian Ocean in 1985 and over the next 29 years visited 80 or so ports around the Indian Ocean littoral. After China joined the international anti-piracy coalition in the Gulf of Aden at the end of 2008, the frequency of PLAN port calls to Indian Ocean littoral ports shot up, but none to Iran, until September 2014, by which time movement toward what became the JCPOA was well underway.[15]

Iranian (but not Chinese) media quoted Xi Jinping's frank words during his January 2016 visit regarding the context and purposes of expanded Iran–China cooperation:

> The countries located along this route [the ancient Silk Road] can, through broadening their cooperation, safeguard their own interests in the face of the Americans' model [which has been designed] to disturb the balance of the regional economy and achieve their goals. … Certain superpowers are seeking to impose monopoly and the jungle policy of "either with us or against us" [on other nations], but the progress of emerging economies has stripped them of the monopoly of power and has [instead] created a proper atmosphere for … ideas and policies of independent governments.[16]

In other words, the time was now right for closer PRC–IRI cooperation. Based on the January 2016 agreements, ambitious transport construction efforts seemed likely to be forthcoming. If Beijing was able to secure access of Iranian ports for logistic servicing of PLAN warships, and if it is able